

Internal Knowledge Document — DO NOT PUBLISH

Cross-reference flag: *This document is mirrored in two repos. Update both copies on edit.*

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- `senzhang-resume/internal/2026-05-XX-gensler-design-technology-interview-prep.{md,pdf}`
- `senzhang.me/internal/2026-05-XX-gensler-design-technology-interview-prep.{md,pdf}`

Part 1 — Situation summary

- **Inbound, not outbound.** Rocco Francica (Gensler Associate, Regional & LATAM Recruiting Lead — North/East) reached you cold around April 28, 2026. You took a Microsoft Teams call April 30 and a follow-up email May 1. He has now asked for your resume so coordinator **Gabby** can schedule meetings with **Islay** and the Design Technology team.
- **Subject line of the chain:** "*Gensler Design Technology*" — that is literally the team and category being recruited for. The role almost certainly maps to one of these live Workday reqs:
 - `R-15809` — Design Technology Lead, Computation
 - `R-17437` — Design Technology Lead, Computation (parallel req)
 - `R-15077` — Regional Design Technology Director
 - `R-15231` — Design Technology Specialist, Data
- **Your honest framing for the Cannon HR meeting on Monday May 5:** Gensler reached you. You did not job-shop. This is market signal, not disloyalty. Use sparingly — don't lead with it, but don't hide it if asked directly.

Part 2 — Who you're meeting

Rocco Francica — Recruiter, not the decision-maker

- **Title:** Regional & LATAM Recruiting Lead, North/East at Gensler (per ZoomInfo)

- **Location:** Piscataway / Morristown NJ. The 212 number on his sig is a forwarded NYC office DID
- **Background:** 3+ years at Aerotek (generalist staffing) before Gensler — **NOT a design-tech specialist; he is a generalist regional recruiter** for Northeast + LATAM hiring
- **Reputation flavor (LinkedIn recs):** client-facing — meaning he works directly with hiring partners (the design-tech leaders), not as a sourcer
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/rfrancica/](https://www.linkedin.com/in/rfrancica/)
- **What he can do:** schedule, advocate, push your candidacy with hiring panel
- **What he cannot do:** judge your technical work, set comp band, or commit to a level
- **Treat him as:** a friendly, professional gatekeeper. Be warm, prompt, professional. Don't get into technical depth with him — save it for Islay.

Islay Burgess, AIA — your interview chair (high-confidence ID)

- **Full title:** Principal, Northeast Regional Design Technology Director, Gensler New York
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/islay-burgess-aia-b788827/](https://www.linkedin.com/in/islay-burgess-aia-b788827/)
- **Gensler bio:** [gensler.com/people/islay-burgess](https://www.gensler.com/people/islay-burgess)
- **Credentials:** Registered Architect (NCARB), AIA, Autodesk Revit-certified
- **Education:** M.Arch + Community Design (USF), B.Arch Engineering (Univ. Southern Mississippi)
- **Pre-Gensler: Thornton Tomasetti CORE studio** — heavyweight computational/structural-tech group; this is parametrics and scripting territory, not just BIM management
- **Areas of focus:**
 - BIM and digital workflows
 - Resilient design
 - **IoT + digital twins** — pulling sensor data into BIM as a live post-occupancy data substrate
 - WPI / EXI (Gensler proprietary research indices) coupled to BIM
 - **Public writing:** [gensler.com/blog/pairing-bim-and-connected-devices-to-elevate-design](https://www.gensler.com/blog/pairing-bim-and-connected-devices-to-elevate-design) — quote: *"pulling live IoT information into BIM to enhance our understanding of energy usage, circulation patterns, environmental factors, and 3D space"*
 - **Tenure signal:** ~15+ years architectural experience, AIA-registered, post-2008 career start
 - **Public speaking / publications:** no ACADIA papers found, no public GitHub
 - **What this means for you:** She runs the team that hires you, and she is the *technical* interview chair, not just a manager. She will judge your portfolio.

Gabby — scheduling coordinator

- Junior coordinator on Rocco's team. No public LinkedIn footprint.
- **When you reply to Rocco's email, ask for Gabby's full name** so you can address her properly in scheduling threads. Zero risk in that ask.

Gensler Design Technology org map (publicly visible 2026)

Tier	Name	Title	Office	LinkedIn
Top of pyramid	Joseph Joseph	Chief Digital Officer, firm-wide	Los Angeles	linkedin.com/in/josephjoseph/
Global Tech practice	Kelly Dubisar	Global Technology Practice Leader, Design Director, Principal	US	(search Gensler People)
Global Tech practice	Naomi Sakamoto	Tech Practice co-leader, Studio Director, Principal	London	—
Your panel chair	Islay Burgess	Principal, NE Regional Design Tech Director	New York	linkedin.com/in/islay-burgess-aia-b788827/
Regional DT Directors	Carolina Montilla	Sr. Associate, Regional DT Director (NW)	San Francisco	linkedin.com/in/carolina-montilla/
Regional DT Directors	Vignesh Kaushik	Principal, Regional DT Director (APME + GC)	Singapore	linkedin.com/in/vigneshkaushik/
AI lead	Aubin Gastineau	Design Director, Sr. Associate; AI lead at NextGen Gensler; teaches ELVTR AI-for-Architects course	Shanghai/LA	linkedin.com/in/aubin-gastineau-908996102/
Likely panelist (NY)	Zach Trattner	Senior Associate, Design Technology Leader, Gensler NY	New York	linkedin.com/in/zach-trattner-774ab5221/
Junior NY team	Daniel Hahn	Design Technology Specialist & Designer; Adj. Prof. NYIT; Columbia GSAPP M.S.	New York	linkedin.com/in/dhahndesign/
Possible panelist (Morristown)	Eric Bieber	Associate Designer, Digital Design lead for Morristown studio	Morristown NJ	linkedin.com/in/eric-bieber-a118a8a4/
Office leadership (Morristown)	Reid Brockmeier	Co-Managing Director, Morristown	Morristown NJ	—
Office leadership (Morristown)	Becky Button	Co-Managing Director, Morristown	Morristown NJ	—
Healthcare x DT	Mariam Osman / Scot Latimer	gFloorz / NFORM authors	various	—

Implication: Your interview panel will likely be **Islay (chair) + Zach Trattner + Eric Bieber if Morristown-sited + possibly Daniel Hahn**. The decision-maker is Islay; Joseph Joseph (CDO) is the firm-level approver for senior offers but won't sit in the room.

Part 3 — Gensler's design-tech identity (what you must NOT step over)

Gensler has invested heavily in proprietary firmwide platforms. Pitching to "build something better" is the fastest way to disqualify yourself. Frame any contribution as **extending the existing platform**, not replacing it.

Platform	What it is	Source
NFORM	Gensler's proprietary BIM/data ecosystem — firmwide design tools, AI integrations, BIM strategy lives here	aecmag.com — "Gensler develops proprietary data-driven design tool"
gFloorz	Floor-plate optimization tool, healthcare + workplace specialty, version 2.0 unveiled by Joseph Joseph + Janet Pogue McLaurin in 2020	Gensler 2020 press
WPI / EXI	Workplace Performance Index / Experience Index — proprietary post-occupancy research indices that Islay specifically couples to BIM	Islay's own writing
AI-for-Architects course (ELVTR)	Aubin Gastineau public course; signal Gensler is publicly bullish on AI in design	elvtr.com/course/ai-for-architects
Design Forecast 2026	Press release titled "AI, Agility, and Adaptation Redefine the Future of Cities"	gensler.com/press-releases/design-forecast-2026-ai-future-cities-trends

Reading order before the interview:

1. Islay's IoT+-BIM essay (above link) — you must reference this in conversation
2. Joseph Joseph's NFORM strategy (any AEC Magazine article)
3. Vignesh Kaushik's public LinkedIn essays on AI/ML in design

Part 4 — How to position yourself (your three sentences)

When Islay asks "tell me what you do" — these three sentences:

"I'm a registered NY architect who's spent five years building Ennead's internal design-automation platform — EnneadTab, 450-plus tools, three U.S. copyright registrations, deployed daily across NYC, LA, and Shanghai. I run that alongside concurrent BIM Manager work on healthcare (NYU Langone, Northwell) and the firm's Asia commercial book (FTZ, ByteDance, Bilibili). The thread connecting all of

it is figuring out how to scale design-technology adoption without breaking designer workflow — which is also the talk I gave at the 2026 Advancing Computational Design Conference in Austin."

That sentence does six things at once: (1) credentials, (2) scope, (3) IP, (4) global delivery, (5) intellectual thread, (6) external recognition. Memorize it.

Part 5 — The three questions to ask Islay

These are calibrated to her actual public writing and Gensler's platform identity. Each one signals you've done the homework without sounding scripted.

1. **"How is the NE region's design-tech team scoped against NFORM and gFloorz 2.0 — do regional DT directors consume the global toolchain, or extend it with regional contributions back to the platform?"**

- *Why this works:* Signals you've read Joseph Joseph's NFORM strategy and understand platform-vs-region tension. Lets Islay describe her actual leverage and budget.

1. **"Your IoT+-BIM digital-twin essay framed BIM as a live post-occupancy data substrate. Where is the team on closing that loop today — is sensor ingestion happening on real projects, or still pilot phase?"**

- *Why this works:* Direct callback to her own published work. Shows you read her writing and respect it. Surfaces whether the role would be greenfield R&D or applied to live jobs — that determines what level you should be slotted at.

1. **"How does the Northeast DT team divide work between Morristown and NY — is the Morristown role primarily client-facing on NJ life-sciences/workplace projects, while NY owns the cross-region computational stack?"**

- *Why this works:* Lets you learn the seat geometry without seeming to negotiate office location, and signals you understand the Eric-Bieber-tier office-level DT vs. Islay-tier regional DT distinction.

Part 6 — Two things to avoid saying cold

1. **DO NOT pitch "we should build our own NFORM-equivalent."** Gensler has invested years and budget in NFORM / gFloorz / WPI / EXI as their proprietary moat. Joseph Joseph (CDO) personally unveiled gFloorz 2.0. Pitching to replace it positions you as not having done your homework. **Frame all contributions as extensions to NFORM, not alternatives.**

1. **DO NOT be dismissive of AI in architecture, or pitch it as hype.** Aubin Gastineau is teaching public AI courses; the Design Forecast 2026 press release leads with AI; Vignesh Kaushik publishes on AI/ML at conferences. **Gensler's public position is bullish-AI.** If you have private skepticism about LLMs in design workflows, phrase it as a *"how is the firm hardening AI outputs against hallucination on regulated code/spec documents"* — a craftsman's question, not a contrarian's.

Part 7 — The likely role + comp range

Best public-data fit for your profile is **Gensler's Design Technology Lead – Computation (R-15809)** in the NE region.

Item	Estimate
Title pattern at Gensler	"Senior Associate, Design Technology Leader" (Trattner is the visible template)
Career-ladder corp title	Senior Associate (P4-equivalent at Gensler)
Likely base band, NYC	\$150K – \$185K (per Glassdoor Gensler Senior Associate NY data: \$108K–\$164K to \$158K–\$252K depending on role)
Bonus	typical 0–15% architecture-firm range
Total comp likely range	\$165K – \$215K

Ceiling stretch: Director of Design Technology / Principal-level if Islay creates the role for you (rare in week-3 of any inbound recruitment, but Gensler has done it for the right specialist hire).

Part 8 — Draft email reply to Rocco

Send this Sunday May 4 (don't reply Saturday — looks too eager) or first thing Monday May 5:

Subject: Re: Gensler Design Technology

>

Hi Rocco,

>

Thanks again for the call last week — good to talk. Resume attached, please share with Gabby and the team.

>

A couple of practical notes for scheduling: - I'm based in NYC and able to do Teams or in-person at either the NY or Morristown office. - I have a flexibility window Tuesday afternoon and most of Wednesday-Friday this week. Mornings are easier than afternoons. - If it helps the panel prep, my current public profile and recent talk are at senzhang.me and 2026-ai-talk.vercel.app respectively.

>

Looking forward to meeting Islay and the team. Happy to talk through any specific projects in advance — just let me know what would help.

>

Best, Sen Zhang Registered Architect (NY) · zsenarchitect@gmail.com · 518.618.6150

What this email does: confirms attached resume, gives concrete availability windows (no back-and-forth), names Islay (signals you know who you're meeting), drops two URLs (lets the panel pre-research you favorably without sounding pushy), offers pre-call (low-cost generous gesture).

Part 9 — How this conversation interacts with Cannon Monday

Three rules:

1. **Do not mention Gensler by name to Cannon HR Monday** unless Cannon HR explicitly asks "have you been approached by other firms?" If asked directly, answer honestly and neutrally: *"I have had inbound conversations from peer firms — I haven't pursued anything actively, but the activity in this market is real, which is part of why I want clarity on my Cannon mapping now rather than later."*
2. **Do not negotiate Gensler comp before knowing Cannon comp.** You're better-positioned with both numbers in hand by mid-June.
3. **Do not panic-accept either side.** Both processes are early. The Gensler call was your first; Cannon mapping is in week-2 of integration. Real decisions land in 30–60 days, not Monday.

Part 10 — Calendar rough timeline

Date	Action
Sun May 3	Read Islay's IoT essay, read NFORM coverage; finalize email draft
Sun May 3 evening	Send email to Rocco with resume attached
Mon May 5	Cannon HR meeting — separate, professional
Week of May 5	Gensler scheduling — first interview likely Islay + 1-2 panelists, 45-60 min
Week of May 12	Likely second-round if first goes well — possibly Joseph Joseph or Zach Trattner deep-dive
Week of May 19	Possible verbal/offer-letter from Gensler if they move fast
Day 60 post-Cannon-close (June 20)	Cannon mapping finalizes; decide

Appendix — Source index

All access date 2026-05-03.

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End of Gensler interview prep. Update with Round-1 outcome notes after the meeting.